

The Spectator



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Lucky Star?

Want to bet the long, longshot?

You'll find plenty of takers in the Valley of the Sun. They figure it's in the bag: All Arizona State's baseball has to do is win two of three games in Phoenix this weekend to hold the lead in the Western Athletic Conference Southern Division.

"We have to win all three," said Coach Frank Sancet, "and I can't remember when we've ever been able to do that in WAC games up there."

Nevertheless Sancet and his Wildcats figure they can do it.

This is a newborn ball club. After dopping two-of-three to the Sun Devils in Tucson and then losing the series opener to New Mexico, Arizona players went into a secret meeting. Since that meeting the Wildcats have won six in a row.

And after that Saturday doubleheader in El Paso, the Cats are convinced they're traveling under a lucky star. After all, how many times do you get two chances to win a game on two-out errors?

All the Wildcats have to do to get back in the WAC race is: 1. defeat the nation's winningest collegiate team in its backyard three times; and 2. hand Larry Gura, the nation's winningest collegiate pitcher, his first defeat of the year.

"We can do it," says Sancet. "We can do it if the kids want to."

Losers' Program

It was really an unexpected pleasure seeing Arizona win that final game Saturday at El Paso. But you had to come away with sympathy for Andy Cohen.

The ex-major leaguer sells beer for a living in El Paso and only on a part-time basis coaches baseball for Texas-El Paso. Despite UTEP's talk about building spring sports before going into the WAC, the school threw all its money into track, leaving baseball an orphan sport.

UTEP baseball has only three scholarships (Arizona has 14 full), it does not have a baseball field of its own (it practices on high school fields, plays games in decrepit Dudley Field) and there aren't even enough of the same uniforms to outfit the entire ball club.

The job Andy Cohen has done this year (winning two WAC games) is miraculous — he didn't deserve to lose what would have been his 'big win' over Arizona on two dropped balls.